



From Afghanistan to Canada: My Family Journey

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1. About My Journey:

In this project, I will share the heartfelt story of my family's journey from Afghanistan to Canada. Leaving Afghanistan was one of the hardest decisions we ever faced. It was not just about saying goodbye to our home, but also to the memories, the laughter, and the love that surrounded us when we were together with family and friends. Even with our happy times, we felt a heavy uncertainty and danger that made it unsafe for us to stay in Afghanistan. In search of safety and a better future, we made the difficult choice to leave everything we knew behind. Coming to Canada was incredibly challenging; the first few years felt heavy with homesickness and the struggles of adjusting to an unfamiliar place and culture. But through it all, my dad's worked really hard and the kindness of the Canadians helped us find our way. Little by little, we began to feel happy again in our new home, rebuilding our lives and finding new joys along the way.



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Chapter1: Background



❖ A happy life in Jalalabad:

Our family's story begins in Jalalabad, a bright and lovely city filled with warm people and rich culture. When I lived there with my family, we had a big house with a beautiful garden **full of fruit trees**, sweet apricots, bright pomegranates, and delicious figs growing wonderfully under the warm Afghan sun and also oranges. We felt so happy surrounded by our friends, who always brought laughter and joy into our lives.

On weekends, we loved going to the local market, where colorful stalls were filled with fresh fruit and vegetables that looked and tasted amazing. My mother would bake bread by hand, filling our home with the lovely smell of warm bread, mixed with the delicious meals she prepared every day.



Family meals were special times. We would sit together on the floor, enjoying our food while sharing stories from our day, laughing, and feeling close to one another. My brother's school was beautiful 🌳 ✨, but my school was simple 🏠. I went to an all-girls school with my sister 👧 👧, while my younger brother and little sister went to another school nearby. Their school was beautiful, with many trees around it 🌳 🌻, and a shiny whiteboard for writing 🖋️.

My school felt old and simple 🕒, with just a chalkboard 📌, but I loved it anyway ❤️. You might wonder why my brother and sisters went to different schools. It's because, in Jalalabad 🌍, only boys went to my brother's school 🧑. Even though we were at different places, we still learned a lot 📖, especially when we sat together and helped each other with studying 😊.

My dad worked as a manager in non-profit organizations and traveled to many countries for his job ✈️🌍. He would go to places like Kabul, Mazar, and sometimes even farther away 🌍. Sometimes, he would be gone for weeks, months, or even a whole year. We missed him so much ❤️ while he was away, but we eagerly waited for him to return 🎉, excited to hear his stories 📖 from all the different places he visited, like the time he brought back traditional crafts 🛍️ from Kabul.



Chapter 2: Our Journey from Jalalabad to Kabul

After many years in Jalalabad, my dad decided to build us a new house in Kabul. 🏠✨ He wanted to be home more often to spend time with us and keep our family together. 👨👩👧 This was a big change for us, and we felt a mix of excitement and sadness 😞 as we prepared to move away from our beloved home and friends.

Packing our things was hard. 📦 Every time we said goodbye, my heart ached 💔, and I felt as if I was closing a chapter in my life. Leaving behind our best friends was not easy, but we were also filled with hope 🌈 for what lay ahead. The journey to Kabul was new and scary. 🚗💨 There were many checkpoints along the way, making every mile feel uncertain. But we found little moments of kindness on our journey, like strangers offering us water 💧 or sharing smiles 😊 with people we met. These small acts showed us that there is still goodness in the world, even in difficult times.

When we finally arrived in Kabul, it was a mixture of feelings. Nervousness and excitement filled us. 😊🎉 The city felt different, yet we were hopeful for the new adventures that awaited us. One winter, something magical happened. ❄️ We saw snow for the first time! It was beautiful, like the world was wrapped in a white blanket. We ran outside to play, laughing and building snowmen 🧊, our hearts filled with joy.

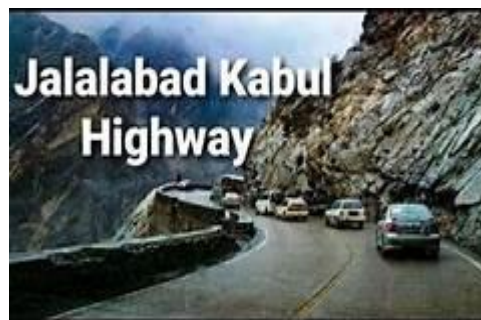
In Kabul, my siblings and I finally attended the same school. 🎒 It was so much fun to wear uniforms, use new books 📚, and even work on computers! 💻 Our classroom was cheerful; we decorated the whiteboard for special days like Eid 🌙 and Teacher's Day. For a long time, we enjoyed our new life together in Kabul, creating wonderful memories 🥳 and supporting each other through everything that came our way.

But after a few years in Kabul, everything changed when we found out that our grandfather had cancer. 😞 My uncles, who are my father's brothers, took him to India to find a good doctor. 🏥 While they were away, we decided to leave Kabul and go to Jalalabad to be with him.

🌍 After about five months, we heard that he was feeling a bit better, so my siblings and I started going to the mosque to learn the Quran, and we also went to school. But after a few months, our grandfather started feeling bad again. 😞 We watched as he grew weaker, and soon, there was nothing we could do to help him.

One day, my sister and I were walking home from school, still feeling happy from the laughter we shared with our friends. 😊 Suddenly, a man on a bicycle came up to us. 🚲 He looked serious, and when he stopped, he asked, “Are you Mr. Habib John’s grandchildren?” We said “Yes.” 🗣️ Then he said, “I am sorry, but your Grandfather has passed away.” 💔 For a moment, we couldn’t believe what we heard. We were like, “No, it couldn’t be true!” 😱 We shook our heads in disbelief, and panic rushed through us.

When we rushed through the door, we felt a heavy sadness in our hearts. 😞 Everyone was screaming and crying. The air was full of sadness, and tears fell from our family’s faces. 😭 Outside, in the yard of our big house, our grandfather lay still and quiet, surrounded by sad faces. Seeing him like that hurt us deeply. 😞 He was the person who brought joy and warmth to our lives, and now everything felt wrong. The pain felt unbearable; the city that once felt full of life now seemed empty and dark. 🌑 Our grandfather was not just anyone in our lives—he was our strong support, our light. ✨ Without him, the world felt like a much sadder place.



Chapter 3: Our Journey from Jalalabad to Pakistan

In 2021, life in Afghanistan became very dangerous. ⚠️ The Taliban took control again, and we were afraid in our town, Jalalabad. 😞 As my dad had been an NGO worker for years, if the Taliban found out about his job, he could be in big trouble. 📁 They did not like educated people like my dad and saw them as enemies. We were always worried that they might kidnap him or hurt him. 😱

Life in Jalalabad became even tougher, as only boys were allowed to go to school. 🎓 Girls like me were not allowed to go to school at all. 🚫 The Taliban only let us go to the mosque, but school was completely off-limits. It was scary to think about what would happen if we even tried to go. 😬 We heard stories about girls who were hurt or even killed for wanting an education. 😞 It was so sad to watch other kids, especially boys, go to school while we had to stay home, worrying about our future and our dreams of learning. 📚

Because of all this danger, my dad made a tough decision. 💔 He decided we needed to leave Jalalabad so our family could be safe. 🏃 He knew that staying there could lead to terrible problems for all of us. Keeping us safe was the most important thing, so he chose to go to Pakistan.

For almost 5 months, my dad lived in Pakistan. 🏠 He and my older uncle worked hard to get the papers and passports we needed to join him. 📄 During this time, we stayed in Jalalabad, feeling scared and not knowing what would happen next. 😞 The Taliban made our daily lives very hard, and we felt stuck.

Finally, after a long wait, my uncle got everything ready for us to leave. 🎉 He finished all the papers, and one night, my oldest uncle came to

take us to Pakistan. 🚗 Leaving our home was one of the saddest moments of my life. 😭 I remember feeling very sad; my mom, my brothers and sisters, and I were all crying as we stepped out of our house for the last time. 😞

It was a dark night, but our happy memories of Jalalabad made us feel warm inside. 🌙 It felt like we were saying goodbye to a place full of our laughter and good times. 🥳 We knew that leaving was needed not just to keep my dad safe, but for our family's future.

Finally, the night came for us to leave. 🕒 As we got into the car, I looked back at our home and the streets we knew. 🚗💨 I felt very sad because we were leaving behind all the places where we had played and laughed. My heart ached at the thought of not coming back. 💔

Even though it was dark, I thought about the happy memories we made in Jalalabad. ✨ We were leaving to be with my dad, and I knew it was important to keep him safe. 👤

Chapter 4: Our Journey in Pakistan

After we left Afghanistan, our family began a long and hard journey into Pakistan. 🌐 We had to go through many checkpoints and travel on many different roads. 🚶 🚶 It was a bit scary and made us feel unsure about what was happening. But finally, we arrived in Islamabad, and my father was there waiting for us. When we saw him, we were so happy! 🎉 It felt like a warm hug, but we were also sad because we had to leave Jalalabad. 😞 Even though we were together again, we couldn't forget what we had left behind.

First Days in Islamabad:

My dad had been in Pakistan for six months before we arrived, working hard to make things better for us. 💪 IOM had booked a nice hotel for him, but sadly, we were not allowed to stay with him in the same hotel. That was a little disappointing. 😞 Luckily, he found another hotel where we could all be together. We stayed there for about four or five days. Sometimes my father was with us, but other times he had to go to his meetings at the other hotel. The first few days were a mix of feelings. We were thankful to have a place to sleep, but we missed our old home very much. 🏠



Searching for Stability:

As time went on, the hotel we were in became very expensive. 💰 So, we needed to find another place to stay. We moved to another hotel where my dad's friend lived. He was very kind and let us stay there for a while. 🤝 We were trying to adjust to our new life, even though it felt uncertain. 😞

After some time, something very sad happened. 💔 My mom's brother had a daughter who was just seven or eight years old, and she passed away. My dad, my older sister, knew about this heartbreaking news, but we decided not to tell my mom. We didn't want her to feel even sadder. 😞

The Hard Truth:

After about a month, we returned to the hotel my dad used to stay in. That was when my mom learned the truth from her brother over the phone. 📞 The news made her very sad, and we could see her heart was breaking. 💔 We felt bad for keeping it a secret, but we had hoped to protect her.

Life in Pakistan continued with its ups and downs, but we stayed close as a family. ❤️ We helped and supported each other during these tough times.

Preparing for Canada:

Finally, after three long months in Pakistan for us and six months for my dad, we received great news: we were ready to go to Canada! Everyone was excited and a little nervous at the same time. 😊

The night before we left, we packed our bags. 🧳 We felt a mix of hope and worry about what was coming next. It was hard to say goodbye to the friends and places we had come to know in Pakistan. 😞 But deep down, we all knew this was a new beginning for us. 🌱

The Departure:

At the airport, there were many steps we had to go through before we could board the plane, and it felt a bit overwhelming. ✈️ Thankfully, my dad knew what to do and helped us through everything. 🙌

When the plane took off and we left Pakistan, I looked out of the window, feeling my heart race with excitement and a bit of fear. 💖 This was a new adventure for our family. Leaving behind everything once again was both scary and freeing. 🌍 We were on our way to a brighter future, and our hearts were full of hope for what was to come.

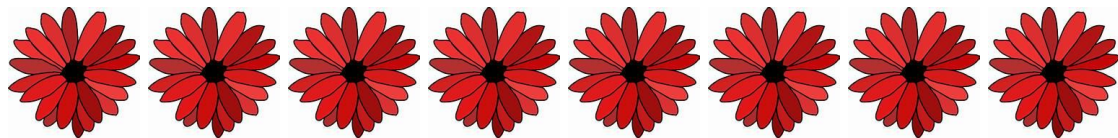


Chapter 6: Starting Our Journey in Canada

When we first arrived in Canada, everything felt different and scary, but we were also excited about starting a new life. 🌍✈️ After we got off the plane, we had to do some important things at the airport. My dad helped us sign papers to show we were immigrants and were ready to begin our new adventure. ✨

After we finished the paperwork, we went to a big place called a reception center. There were other families who had just arrived in Canada too. We felt a mix of feelings, some happy and some nervous as we saw all the new faces around us. 😊👥

At the center, we had to check our health, which included getting some vaccinations. 💉 The staff there spoke English and were very nice. They explained everything we needed to know. After that, they told us we would stay in a hotel called the Best Western in Calgary for a little while. 🏨



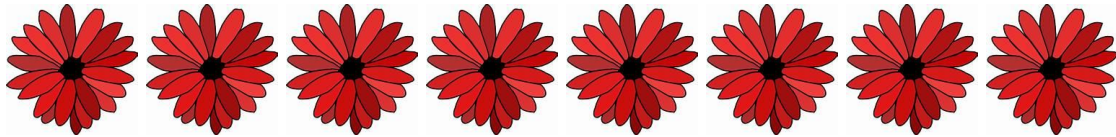
Life in the Hotel:

We lived in that hotel for about one and a half months. 📅 It was a different experience for us, and it felt like we couldn't go out much. We could only leave the hotel if we needed to. There was a restaurant in the hotel where we could eat. 🍴 Most of our meals came from there, and it was nice because they served food that felt a bit like home. ❤️

In the hotel, I met many other families who were also new to Canada. We shared stories and made new friends. 😊 We played games together and sometimes watched movies in our rooms. 🎬 But sometimes I felt a bit lonely because I was still getting used to everything. After about a month, staff members—whom we called our counselors—moved us to another hotel that was better for Afghan

families. Here, we could talk about our plans and get help finding a place to live. 🏠

Our counselors taught us many important things. 💡 They showed us how to look for a house and where to get help. They explained how to visit a doctor if we were not feeling well. They also showed us how to get a driving license and helped us figure out where to go to school. 📖 They explained that we would need to register for school and that there would be some testing to see what grade we should be in before we start. This was exciting because I wanted to make new friends and learn in my new school. 🎉 They helped us find resources from other groups, teaching us so many useful skills that made moving to Canada feel less scary. With their help, we learned how to buy groceries and even how to use the bus to get around. 🚌 It made us feel more at home.



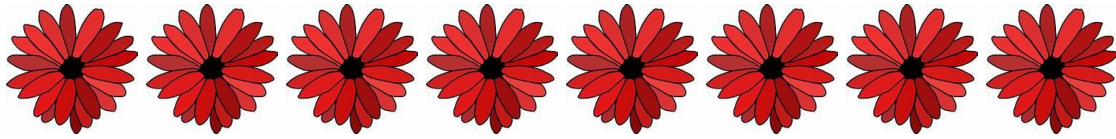
Thank You Letter to Our Counselors:

Dear Counselors,

I want to say a big thank you for all the help you gave us. 🙏 You made our time in the hotel much easier and more comfortable. Your kind words and support helped us feel less alone in a new country. Thank you for teaching us how to find a house, how to visit the doctor when we are sick, and how to register for school. 🏠 I really appreciate everything you did for us. I feel excited about my new life in Canada because of your guidance! 🌈

With gratitude,

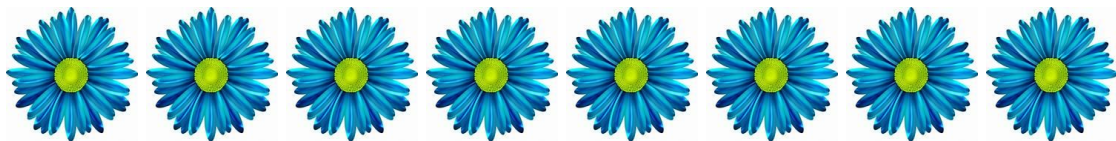
Arzo Samim



Finding Our Home:

After a few weeks, we finally found a house in Harvest Hills, Calgary. 🏠 It was our first real home in Canada, and moving in was a big step for us. But the first few months were hard because everything was new. 🌨️ Winter came fast, and we had lots of snowstorms. ❄️ It looked beautiful outside, but it made things tough to get used to.

That first year, we didn't have a car. 🚗 My dad needed to study for his driving tests in the freezing cold. I remember watching him while we all put on warm clothes to stay cozy in the cold weather. Every morning was hard because we had to walk about 15 minutes to the bus stop for school. 🚌 My little sister's bus stop was even farther at 25 minutes. My parents took turns walking her, wearing their warm coats, hats, and scarves to protect against the cold. 🧣



Overcoming Challenges:

Buying groceries was hard too. Without a car, my dad had to take the city bus to the supermarket. 🛒 Carrying heavy bags of food home was tiring, especially in the cold. There were days we didn't know how we would manage, but we kept hoping things would get easier. 🌈

During our first year in our new home, we received a lot of help from kind Canadians. 🤝 They showed us where to find community resources like food banks, which helped us a lot. Thanks to their help, we learned about many places that could support us as we settled down.

Finally, after more than a year, my dad passed his driving tests! 🎉
We were so happy! Now he could take us grocery shopping, drive us
to school, and help us explore our new city. 🏙️

The first year was not easy, but we started to feel more comfortable
and settled in Canada. We were learning how to live in our new home,
facing challenges, but also enjoying new experiences. ☀️



Finding Our Place in Canada:

As time passed, we started to feel more comfortable and at home in
Canada. 🏠 We began to enjoy our new lives, making friends at
school and in our neighborhood. 😊 My siblings and I went to local
schools where we learned English together. It was fun to join in class
discussions and take part in activities that helped us learn about our
new culture. 🎓

During this time, my mom worked hard in her English classes, which
made us feel better as we talked with friends and neighbors. We met
other Pashto and Persian families in our community. 🌐 We shared
stories about our lives and made new memories together. 💕

Even though we loved our new life in Canada, there were still times
when we missed our old home in Jalalabad and Kabul. 🌅 We
remembered the happy times with family and the places we knew well.
Talking about our past helps us stay connected to Afghanistan, even
as we created a new life in this bright and lively country. 😊

With determination and strength, we turned our experiences into a
wonderful mix of two worlds. 🌈 We honored our Afghan traditions
while welcoming the new chances Canada gave us. Each day brought

its own ups and downs, and I looked forward to the adventures still to come. 🌟

Chapter 7: Our Happy Life in Canada

Today, my family and I are very happy to live in **Canada**. We have created a warm home full of **joy**. ❤️ We are lucky to have many **Afghan families nearby**. 🌐 We enjoy going to **parties** and **weddings** where we celebrate our **culture** with music, dancing, and tasty food. 🎉🍴 These special events help us feel close to our **roots** while also being part of our **new home**.

My mom works hard to **learn English**. 📖 She goes to classes and practices at home. I admire her because she tries so hard to **speak and connect** with others. Her efforts help her feel more **sure of herself** in our new community.

My dad was a **respected man in Afghanistan**, but now he drives for **Uber** to support us. 🚗 He wakes up early and works long hours to make sure we have everything what we need. Sometimes I think about how **different** his life is now, but he does this with **love for our family**. ❤️ Without his hard work, life would be much harder for us.

My older sister has started **high school**, and she is excited to learn new things and make friends. 🏠 My brother and I are still in **junior high**, and we try our best in school. We feel lucky to learn **English** and other subjects.

Even though life can be hard, we are very **grateful** for our life here. 🙏 We know we must work hard to reach our **dreams**, just like our parents. Our family is strong, and together we look forward to a **bright future**. 🌟 We are proud to be part of this **community** and ready to

help others, just like the **kind Canadians** who helped us when we arrived.

Chapter 8: Thank You Letter to the Kind Canadians

Dear Kind Canadians, ✨

I want to take a moment to express my **heartfelt gratitude** 💖 for all the **support** and **kindness** you showed my family and me during our **challenging journey**. Arriving in Canada 🍁 was both **exciting and overwhelming**, and your warm welcomes made a world of difference.

From the moment we stepped off the plane, you embraced us with open arms. 😊 Your smiles, encouraging words, and generous acts helped us feel less alone in a new and unfamiliar land. Whether it was helping us find housing, guiding us through the healthcare system, or showing us how to navigate daily life, your **kindness has been a light** in our lives. 💡

As we began to **rebuild** our lives here, your help allowed us to focus on our dreams. 🌈 You've shown us that Canada is not just a place to live; it is a **community** filled with **caring individuals** who support one another. Thank you for believing in us and for giving us a chance to enjoy ourselves. 🌻 We will always remember your kindness, and we look forward to giving you back to this **wonderful country** that has welcomed us so warmly. 🙏 I would like to say thank you so much again for supporting us.

Thank you. ❤️



Chapter 8: Our Dreams for the Future

As my siblings and I grow up in Canada, we each have big dreams for our future. The journey we've taken from Afghanistan has shown us the importance of helping others, and we want to make a positive impact in our new community. 🌍

I really want to become a doctor. 🩺 I want to help people who are sick and make them feel better. I remember the doctors who cared for my grandfather when he was sick; they showed such kindness, and I want to be like them. I hope to study medicine and learn all the skills I need to help those in need. My dream is to help sick people, but I also want to make sure everyone can get the healthcare they need. I want to help those who feel like nobody cares about them. 💖

My older sister wants to be a nurse. She loves math and science, and she is excited to help people. She wants to work in a hospital and care for others. She believes that with her skills, she can make Canada a better place for everyone.

My younger brother is not sure what he wants to be when he grows up. Sometimes he wants to be a pilot and fly planes. Other times, he thinks about being a police officer to help people. Sometimes he even wants to be a doctor to take care of sick people. He is still thinking about different jobs. ✨

Together, we often talk about how we want to support people in our community, just as we were supported when we arrived in Canada. We hope to volunteer, mentor others who may be going through difficult times, and contribute to making the world a better place. 🤝

As we look forward to our future, we are filled with hope and determination. ✨ We know that with hard work and the lessons we've learned from our journey, we can achieve our dreams. We are excited about the opportunity to give back to the country that has given us a home, a warm community, and a chance to start anew. 🌈

Conclusion

As I think about my family's journey from **Afghanistan** to **Canada**, I understand that everyone has their own special path, filled with challenges and hardships. Leaving my home was one of the hardest things we ever had to do. We faced **fear**, **sadness**, and **uncertainty**, but through it all, we found **hope** and **love**. ❤️

Every step of our journey taught us about being strong. 💪 Whether it was the **laughter** we shared in our garden in Jalalabad or the new friends we made in Canada, we found ways to lift each other's spirits. Even during tough times, we learned that **kindness** can be found everywhere, from the help of strangers to the warmth of our neighbors. 🌻

I wish I could share photos to show how much we've changed, but my family likes to keep our memories private. They believe that those special moments should stay in our hearts and not be shared online. This reminds me that our experiences together are the most important part of our journey. 💖

As you can see, I have added some emojis 🌸 ✨ because it is my favorite thing to do when writing paragraphs, especially now that I am working on this project. Honestly, I received a lot of help from my older sister, Marwa Samim. She assisted me with the design 🎨; whenever she shared her ideas, I took notes and added them to my project. My dad and mom also helped me by encouraging me with their thoughts

😊, and my dad also helped me with editing ✍️. Thank you for your support! 🙏

Our story reminds us that while the world can be a hard place, there is always **light** to help us move forward. It shows that in every challenge, we can find **strength**, and in every goodbye, we can look forward to new beginnings. 🌈

I hope our journey inspires you to appreciate your own story and to see that, no matter where we come from, we are all connected by our shared experiences of **love**, **loss**, and **hope**. Thank you for taking the time to read about our journey. Together, we can build a future filled with **understanding** and **kindness**. 🌍💕

Best Regards,

Arzo Samim



Final Thoughts:

I want to thank you for reading my family's story. Our journey showed me that even when times are tough, we can find strength in each other. I hope our story helps you understand that everyone has their own hard times, but kindness can make things better.

I encourage you to be kind and help others whenever you can. Just like the kind Canadians who helped us when we arrived, we can all make a difference in someone's life. Let's all try to share love and support in our communities. Thank you for being part of our journey! 🌈